

Carolina Raptor Center Touts Birds Of Prey

Just seven miles north of Charlotte—as the bird flies—nests a sanctuary which is almost out of this world. A peaceful sylvan grove, the Carolina Raptor Center is home to about 75 magnificent birds of prey, who will spend the rest of their grounded days here and who highlight the otherworldliness of this place.

Eagles, owls, hawks, falcons, vultures, ospreys. All seriously injured or otherwise “non-releasable” into the wild, these great birds comprise one of the most interesting and precious collections of winged predators in the entire southeast.

Technically, a bird of prey is a raptor, a term taken directly from Latin, meaning “robber, plunderer, one which seizes and carries off.” But, to see these disabled kestrels and great horned owls in their shaded aviaries does not evoke images of raptorial violence.

In fact, the diminutive peregrine falcon, perched on his shelf, almost belies his reputation as the fastest-in-dive of all the birds of the world. Able to spot its prey at a great distance, his resume claims, the peregrine can dive at speeds approaching 200 miles an hour and seize its victim in mid flight.

And yet, despite its awesome “specs,” this beautiful bird, along with his fellow residents at the Carolina Raptor Center, will never again even fly.

The raptor center, located in Latta Plantation Park just north of Charlotte, came into existence in 1979 committed to environmental education and to the conservation of birds of prey through rehabilitation, research and reproduction.

Principally, explained Laura Keistler, development director, the center’s mission is to rehabilitate injured birds of prey. And, along with this mission, the center educates the public about how to prevent injury to them and conducts research about raptors, and breeds birds using non-releasable parents.

At any given time, Keistler said, the center has 60 - 75 birds in residence. Many of the birds are permanent residents, in 18 aviaries located along a half-mile nature trail. “At the moment,” she said, “we have 22 species of birds here at the center.”

“We have here at the center a rehabilitation hospital, where injured birds are treated by volunteer veterinarians. The birds are fed a proper diet of mice and rats. If a bird has the potential to be released, it is put in the flight cage, where it can practice catching live prey and flying. If the bird does all right, then we release it as close to its natural habitat as is possible.”

The Carolina Raptor Center is a non-profit organization, supported by individual memberships and donations, corporate donations, foundation grants, gift

shop sales and education program fees. Keistler stressed that the center receives no government funding, neither city, county, state or federal.

Presently, the full time staff numbers six with one part-time assistant.

“Volunteers make it possible to maintain the center,” Keistler emphasized. “They are an extremely dedicated group. They clean cages, help to rehabilitate birds, maintain the nature trails, run the gift shop, help to put on the educational programs, build cages. They are indispensable.”

“Raptors share three important characteristics,” Keistler said. “They have curved, sharp talons and beaks and they have acute eyesight.” She provided an example of the astonishing eyesight of hawks and eagles, “which, while still above the tree line, can spot small rodents on the ground!”

At the vulture aviary, Keistler mentioned the bad press that these birds have received. “One of the reasons for the bad rep,” she said, “is that they are bald, which detracts from their appearance. However, we refer to them as ‘nature’s sanitation crew.’”

At the bald eagle enclosure, Keistler explained that the lady’s name is Queen Charlotte, the gentleman’s, Sir Raleigh. “Each has had one wing amputated, the injuries caused by gunshot.” She said that Zlaty, a Golden Eagle who has been resident for nine years, was also the victim of a gunshot wound. She has had one wing amputated. Zlaty is also a non-stop conversationalist.

Raptors play a functional role in the scheme of things. Keistler said that raptors control the populations of snakes, mice, rats

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and certain birds such as starlings. “Also,” she said, “they are excellent environmental indicators, being among the first in nature to evidence the presence of harmful pollutants and pesticides. Raptors will show the negative effects of pesticides such as DDT before these substances cause serious harm to humans.”

Keistler said, “Most of the owls which are brought here have been hit by automobiles. The owls fly in low over the highway to catch rodents feeding on trash discarded from passing autos. Frequently, they are struck by passing vehicles. Those owls which survive incur serious wing and eye injuries.”

“We also work closely with hunters, educating them to recognize the raptors. We feel that most of the gunshot injuries to these birds are accidental. We educate hunters about the threat to endangered birds, and also some of the penalties to those caught harming or killing birds of prey.”

Keistler pointed out that the center has gotten support from the North Carolina Gun Club. “Each year, the center maintains an exhibit at the Buckarama, which is the hunting community’s annual exposition.”

Visiting hours at the Carolina Raptor Center are 10 - 5, Tuesday through Sunday. Birds

are exhibited in the “weathering area” for close-up viewing and photo opportunities on Saturday and Sunday, between noon and 5, weather permitting.

Keistler said that there are many possibilities for involvement in the work of the center. Keistler cited the example of the Southern Bell Telephone Pioneers, who donated and planted 100 Dogwood trees along the Nature Trail and donated money for the construction of an education aviary along the trail.

Keistler also mentioned the Adopt-A-Bird of Prey program - adopting one of the resident birds at the center. The adoption fee is used to help care for “your” bird and others to carry on the center’s work. You may choose the species you wish to sponsor when you adopt an

educational bird. You receive a 5x7 color photo of your bird, its life history and a parchment adoption certificate, suitable for framing. Adoptions are for a one year period.

Admission to the Carolina Raptor Center: \$2 for adults; \$1 for senior citizens and students. Children under 6 are admitted free when accompanied by parent - otherwise, \$1. Center members are admitted free. Family memberships are also available. For more information, call (704) 875-6521.

And come out to NorthFest on Saturday, October 2, at Magnolia Plaza in Cornelius and meet some of our spectacular and captivating raptors

*By George Fitzpatrick
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